DESIGNING MEETINGS

Designing Effective Meetings

How to design a meeting before it starts: name its goal (decide, inform or generate), right-size the invite list, and choose a format that fits the goal.

What this resource is for

Many meeting problems are decided before the meeting starts: what the meeting is for, who is invited, and which format it uses. This resource covers these three design choices in that order. Each choice should serve the one before it.

Start with the goal

Before building an agenda, name the meeting's goal. Most meetings quietly try to do more than one of the following at once, which is usually why they run long and satisfy no one.

Decide means a choice needs to be made, and someone in the room has the authority to make it. A meeting with a Decide goal should end with a clear decision, or a clear statement of what is still missing before one can be made.

Inform means people need the same information at the same time, and no decision is required. If the only goal is to share information, it is worth asking honestly whether a meeting is even the right format, since a well-written update often achieves the same thing without needing everyone's calendar at once.

Generate means new ideas or options are needed before any decision is possible. This is divergent work, and it should not be squeezed into the same slot as a Decide conversation, because groups that are still generating options are not ready to commit to one of them yet.

Naming the goal before building the agenda matters because an agenda that does not know its own goal usually tries to do all three badly: it opens with information sharing, drifts into generating new ideas halfway through, and then runs out of time to actually decide anything. Once the goal is named, the agenda, the invite list, and the format all become much easier to design, because each of those choices should serve that one goal rather than trying to serve several at once.

Right-size the invite list

Every extra person in a meeting is a cost, not just to their own time but to the group's ability to move quickly and speak freely. Right-sizing the invite list is worth doing deliberately, before touching the agenda.

Three questions help with this. Whose decision is this, really? This connects to stakeholder segmentation: the people whose formal authority or accountability makes this genuinely their call belong in the room. Whose work depends on the outcome, even without a formal say in it? These people may not need to shape the decision, but they need to know about it, and leaving them out because they lack formal authority often creates exactly the kind of late surprise that stakeholder management is meant to prevent. Finally, who could this be handled with asynchronously, or afterwards, instead? Not every stakeholder needs to be in the room for the whole conversation. A short written update, or a five-minute conversation after the fact, is sometimes the better way to keep someone genuinely informed without inflating the meeting itself.

This is also where delegation and stakeholder segmentation connect directly to meeting design. A meeting that has quietly grown to include every possible stakeholder "just in case" is usually a symptom of discomfort with delegation: inviting everyone feels safer than deciding who actually needs to be there, but it produces a slower, more cautious conversation with less genuine ownership from anyone in it.

Choose the format

Once the goal is named and the invite list is right-sized, the format should follow the goal rather than defaulting to whatever format the last meeting used. Six recurring formats cover most working meetings.

Brainstorm is best for generating options before narrowing them down. Watch out for groupthink if the most senior voices speak first; a short round of individual, silent idea generation before opening the floor helps counter this.

Decision protocol is best when a clear decision needs to be made with input from several people. Watch out for making this feel heavier than the decision actually warrants; a low-stakes call does not need a full protocol.

Status or information share is best for keeping people aligned when no decision is needed. Watch out for the fact that this is often better handled with a written update than a meeting at all.

Structured retrospective is best for reflecting on a recurring practice in order to improve it. Watch out for the fact that this format needs real trust in the room; without it, feedback stays surface-level and the retrospective produces little of value.

Open discussion is best for exploring a genuinely open question that does not yet have a clear shape. Watch out for drift; an open discussion without a visible timebox can wander indefinitely without reaching anywhere useful.

Review or approval is best for checking a piece of work, a proposal, or a deliverable against a known standard or set of criteria before it moves forward. Watch out for rubber-stamping, where reviewers have not actually engaged with the material beforehand, or for drifting into open debate when the approval criteria were never made clear at the outset.

Try it: redesign a recurring meeting

Take one real, recurring meeting from your own work, on your own or with a colleague, and redesign it: name its actual goal, decide who truly needs to be there, choose the format that fits, and commit to one concrete change for next time. It is worth repeating this whenever a recurring meeting starts to feel like it has drifted from its original purpose.

Online version with links to related resources: https://resources.simsab.net/effective-meetings/designing-effective-meetings